

REVIEW

Do school smartphone bans improve grades and mental health?

REFERENCES	STYLE	MADE WITH	VERIFICATION	COMPILED
10 verified	Bullets	Grounded v0.5.1	Crossref · claims	4 Sep 2026

SUMMARY

School phone restrictions may help some pupils, but dependable improvements in grades or mental health remain uncertain. Confidence in these outcomes is low: studies compare different policies and measure different kinds of success.

01 Less school-time use does not establish better wellbeing

- >> Restrictive English schools had lower school-time phone use than permissive schools, with an adjusted difference of **−0.67 hours daily**; this was an observational association.¹
- >> Overall weekday and weekend phone use showed no detectable difference between policy groups.¹

- >> A rapid review reported a small pooled benefit across academic and social outcomes, but explicitly cautioned that academic evidence was limited.²
- >> Figure 1 separates the immediate school-time association from the uncertain academic and wellbeing outcomes.

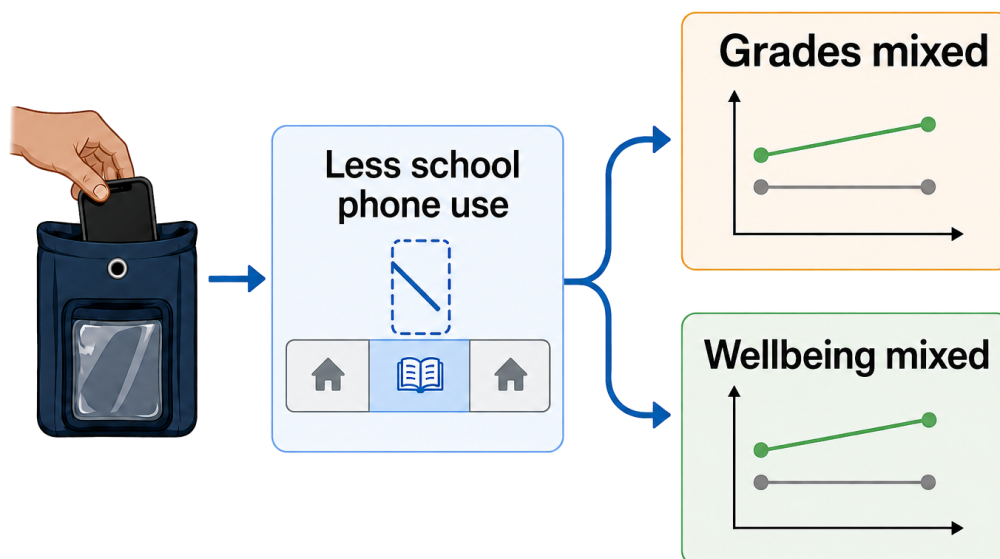


Figure 1. School use and student outcomes. Restrictive English policies were associated with less school-time use.¹ The rapid review found a small pooled benefit.² Lines are qualitative summaries, without numerical scales or a causal effect estimate.

02 Academic gains depend on the outcome and setting

- >> Test-score gains followed regional bans in Galicia, Spain; the authors expressed the maths gains as **0.6–0.8 years of learning**.³
- >> Academic engagement showed no detectable advantage in a preregistered South Australian comparison after one month.⁴
- >> The two findings therefore answer different questions: a short engagement assessment cannot settle whether examination grades improve over years.

03 Mental-health findings include benefits and null results

- >> Lower psychological distress was associated with bans in a secondary South Australian analysis; its abstract describes the difference as small.⁵
- >> English schools with restrictive policies showed no evidence of better mental wellbeing.¹
- >> Dutch schools with full bans showed no detectable wellbeing or bullying advantage over classroom-only bans.⁶

>> Anxiety increased during a Hungarian mobile-free day; its brief, within-school design limits conclusions about permanent policies.⁷

COMPARISON	OUTCOME	FINDING	SOURCE
English restrictive versus permissive schools	Wellbeing score	Adjusted difference -0.48; 95% confidence interval -2.05 to 1.06	¹
South Australian ban versus no-ban schools	Academic engagement	Standardized difference 0.03; 95% confidence interval -0.14 to 0.20	⁴
Dutch full versus classroom-only bans	Wellbeing and bullying	No significant differences	⁶

04 A plausible mechanism does not settle policy effectiveness

>> Better recall followed phone removal in an undergraduate laboratory task, which did not test school grades or mental health.⁸

>> A review linked heavier smartphone use with poorer academic performance, while warning that the underlying associations could not establish causation.⁹

>> Figure 2 marks the separate steps between putting a phone away, performing a task, and improving student outcomes.

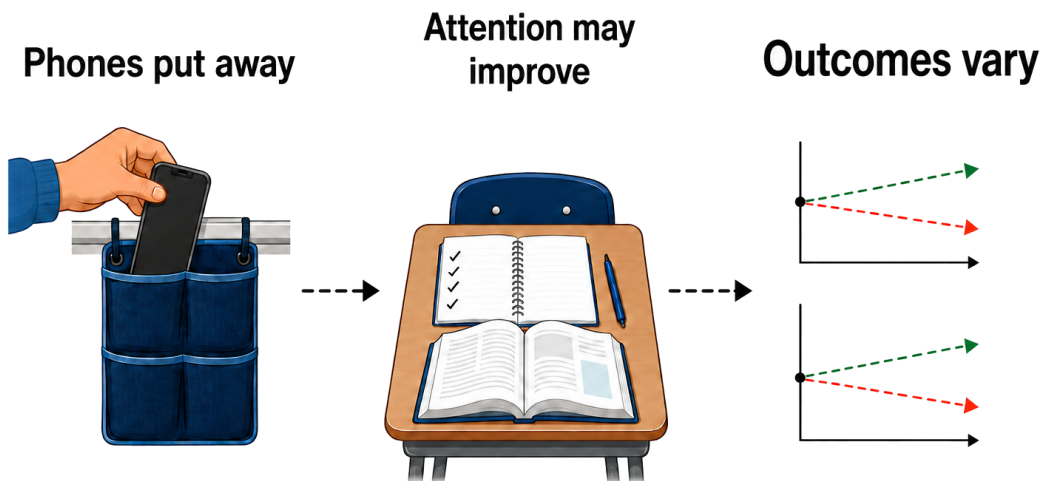


Figure 2. From restriction to outcomes. Phone absence improved laboratory recall.⁸ Restrictive school policies were not associated with better English pupil wellbeing.¹ Dashed connections represent uncertain transitions; outcome paths are schematic, not measured trajectories.

>> The recurring pattern is a gap between restricting access and demonstrating lasting benefit. A qualitative SMART Schools follow-up described benefits and drawbacks under both policy types.¹⁰

>> Low confidence leaves room for context-specific benefit; the present comparisons do not establish a reliable policy effect across schools.

trary findings. Peer-reviewed policy comparisons informed conclusions; laboratory and general-use studies supplied context. Five cited papers were read in full and five through abstracts. The Australian analyses and SMART Schools publications were grouped by study family. Review overlap was not treated as independent replication. Crossref screening found no integrity signal on the search date; several publisher notice pages were inaccessible.

Scope and methods — Narrative review; OpenAlex and PubMed searches on 4 September 2026 included recent and con-

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